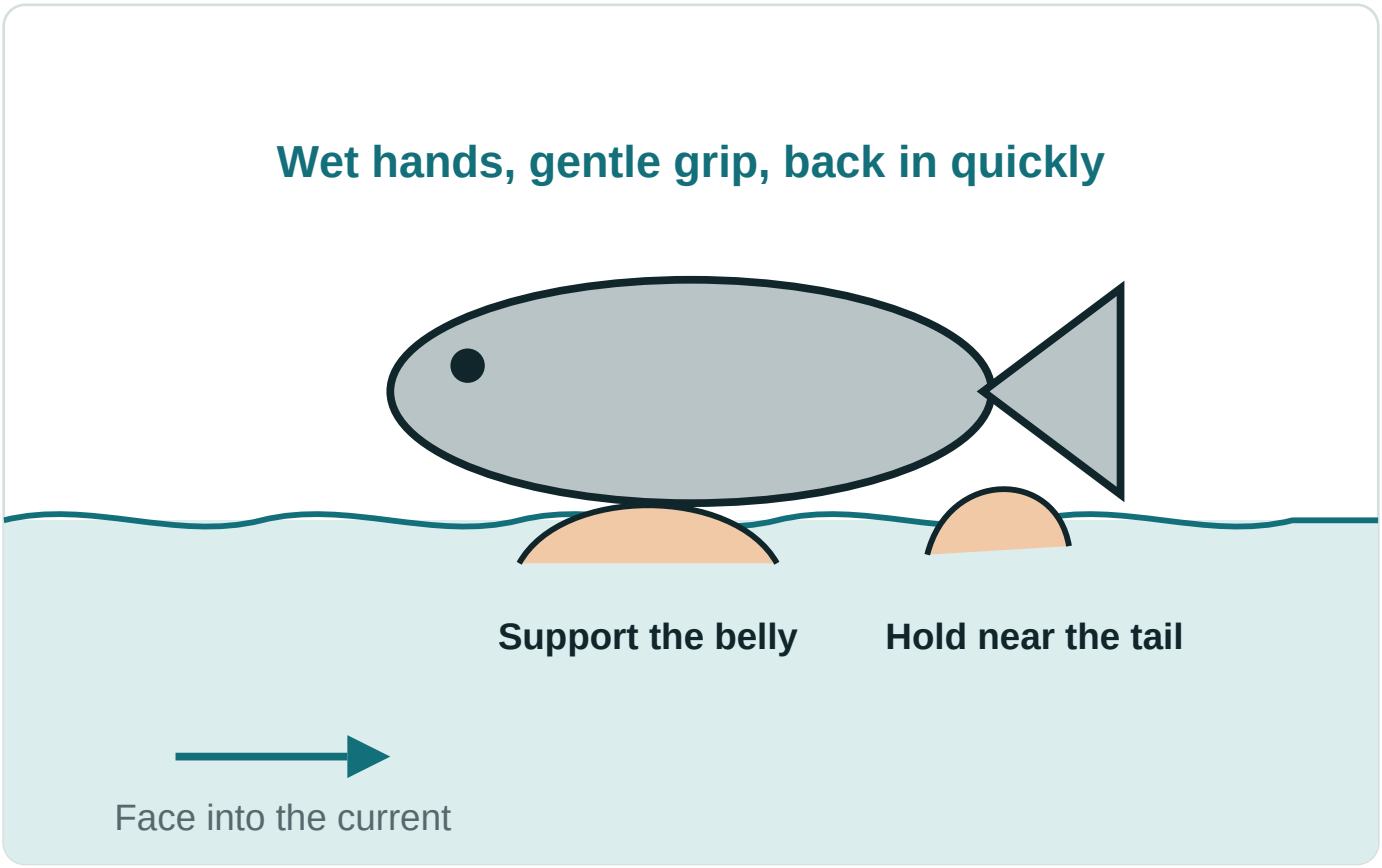
FISHY FRIENDS GUIDE

Handling and releasing fish

Good for: Bream, Flathead, Tailor, Kingfish, Snapper, Whiting

Undersize fish, oversize flathead and everything caught west of the Harbour Bridge goes back. Do it gently and quickly.



YOU NEED

Wet hands or a wet towel, long-nose pliers, a ruler or measuring sticker on your rod.

STEPS

1. Wet your hands before touching the fish. Dry hands rub off their protective slime.
2. Hold the fish gently: one hand under the belly, one near the tail. Never squeeze.
3. Keep it in or over the water as much as you can. Lay it on a wet surface to measure, never on hot concrete.
4. Use pliers to back the hook out. If it's swallowed deep, cut the line close to the mouth instead.
5. Hold it upright in the water, facing into the current, until it swims off by itself.
6. Watch out for spines (flathead, leatherjacket) and teeth (tailor, kingfish).

KID TIP Be quick and gentle. Count to 30: the fish should be back in the water before you finish!

STAY SAFE Flathead have sharp spikes on the sides of their head. Hold them from behind with a wet towel.

Watch: Catch and release tips (NSW DPI)

More videos: search YouTube for "how to release a fish safely"